



Looking Them Over

With HENRY JURRAS
Times-Argus Sports Editor

Umpire, Artie Gere

The words flowed freely, with sincerity and a deep conviction as Johnny Angwin chauffeured our guest, Artie Gere, to the airport following Saturday night's banquet for the Little Leaguers.

With two newspapermen on his heels, Artie took his cue nicely. "Well boys, start firing — what do you want to know? How long were you an umpire in the National League?"

"I got my baptism in the bigtime in 1947 and after 10 wonderful years, I abruptly was given the 'pink slip', just like that.

"It's a long story, and I'd rather you didn't quote me. Perhaps I left under a dark, misgiving cloud, but believe me—I was guilty of nothing. I think Joe Cronin, then the big man in the Boston Red Sox organization, erased my slate clean when he offered to recommend that I be accepted as an umpire into the American League. Generous as the offer was, I was too heartbroken to consider it."

Would you do it all over again, Artie?

"Yes, with one exception, I danged well would see to it that I got a good education first of all. That's why I wanted to impress the kids tonight that an education is a must.

What about the umpires who claim "they never missed one" — did you?

"I missed plenty of 'em in my time," mused Artie with a chuckle. "Shucks, if I thought I missed only six or seven pitches in a game, I considered it a good day.

"That fella you're referring to (Bill Klem) originated the saying, but what he meant was that in his own heart he felt he hadn't made a bad call."

How come when umpires dust off the plate they never turn their back to the fans in the grandstand?

"Oh, that, it's simply a gesture of respect.

"I've got to tell you this one," said Artie, "before you ask me. I reversed myself on a decision one time and got away with it.

"It happened one rainy misty night in Brooklyn when Duke Snider hit a savage liner down the line and I immediately gave the sign that it was a home run. All at once I discovered the ball hadn't gone into the stands. I told Scotty Robb (onetime umpire in Vt.'s Northern League) that I had pulled a rock. We decided at best that Duke could have made three bases so awarded him a triple instead of the homer. Brooklyn put in a protest but it never stood up...we figured that was one for the weak side."

"You know," he continued, "the money-hungry baseball magnates are making it rough on both umpires and ball players with their insatiable lust for the gold that night games bring in.

"Guys get tired out there and the reflexes aren't what they should be. Eating habits get fouled up, too. Remember when the Phils' Bubba Church got all busted up by a line drive from Ted Kluszewski's bat? I still think it wouldn't have happened if he hadn't played in a night game the day before and then had to drag out of bed and go to work again. The first game of that twin-bill went 9 innings and the nightcap

ended after 19 innings — imagine that! And don't think the umpires aren't taking a licking, they do.

"Another damaging feature of night games is that in the long run the kids, future baseball fans, won't be around one of these days. Parents justifiably don't want them at night games and coming in all hours of the night. The result is the kids will slowly lose interest.

"Yes, umpiring is a bit different in both leagues. In the National they give a pitcher that low one around the knees and it's murder when those guys start tossing those dipping pitches. The umps give you the high one in the American, but I think umpiring is probably better organized in the American League.

"Of course, calling balls and strikes is never tough when you get fellows like Stan Musial, Red Schoendienst and Gil Hodges at the plate. That threesome is the finest caliber of gent's the game ever saw.

"I think, too, that the National League is more colorful. It has an abundance of great talent pretty well distributed and all the teams will run on you at any time.

Gore told some good stories at the banquet that had the crowd in stitches. There was the day in the John McGraw regime when Andy Cohen, a Jewish ball player on the Giant team was sent in to pinch-hit for Shanty Hogan.

Over the loud speaker it came: Cohen batting for Hogan and back from the bleachers came the echo: "Yes, and Flanagan is leaving the ball park!"

Another time, Artie recalled the day Lefty Gomez of the Yankees fell away from a pitch and accidentally hit a two-bagger. Lefty, nearly delirious over it all, promptly stole third base. Then he told Art Fletcher, third base coach, "I think I can steal home on this guy."

That was too much for Fletcher who cried: "It's the first time you've been on third base in 13 years — don't louse it up now."

Just before Gore boarded the plane for his home in Lexington, Mass., he said he couldn't wait to get home. "I got a wonderful wife. I'm the last of 14 children, one of triplets, when dad went for the long ball, I guess."

We liked and admired Artie Gore, a sincere, even humble man who is deeply religious.

And as the plane reared into the black night, you couldn't help but think there went a man wonderfully suited to spread the gospel of baseball.

Bridge Tourney

BERLIN, N.H. — The Berlin Bridge Club is sponsoring a Bridge Tournament, the First Annual Paper City Open Pairs, at Hotel Costello, on Saturday, Sept. 26, the first session at 2 p.m. and second session, 7:30 p.m. Entry fee is \$1.25 per session.

All bridge enthusiasts are invited to attend. Trophies will be awarded. The usual ACBL Master Point awards will be given.

Director of the Berlin Bridge Club, which is host to the tourney, is Mary F. Dresser. Inquiries concerning the tourney should be addressed to Miss Dresser at Hotel Costello, Berlin, N. H.